

▼ TAMIL NADU

WAR OF WORDS

Yes, literally. If you had trouble catching that pun, make that 'war over words'. Linguistic pride has, well, pride of place as one of the founding strands of Tamil Nadu's Dravidian politics. Consequently, it's never been too tough to flash the spectre of 'Hindi imposition' to get the native choir to sing in harmony during voting time.

The Centre's renewed invocation of the three-language formula, as a compulsory setting for CBSE schools from Class 6, has only made it a handier plank to deploy, giving **M.K. Stalin** a red rag to wave about. "Not as long as the DMK is in power," the CM declares emphatically, in response to Union education minister **Dharmendra Pradhan**'s imprecations. Like many of his predecessors, he also questioned the lack of reciprocity. Would students in Hindi-speaking states be required to learn southern languages?

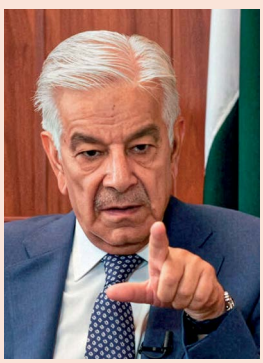
Party MP Kanimozhi gave it a comic-grandiose twist, calling the polls a civilisational contest between "Nagpur and Keezhadi".

▼ WEST BENGAL

CLOSE-SHAVE DEMOCRACY

Lalu Prasad Yadav of Bihar was a master at this genre of street theatre: he has famously given a roadside shave to a customer, and hosed down a slum boy non-millionaire. More recently, RaGa has dirtied his hands at a mechanic's shop, sowed paddy, driven a truck, worn a coolie's garb to cart luggage, and sailed out to sea with fishermen. The show now comes to Bengal. The run-up to voting, otherwise fraught and fractious, has given itself a lighter human touch as more than one neta reprised the common man—and woman—persona. Maybe a wee short of method acting, since it's only a walk-on part for an election campaign, but the roles do have variety.

Anup Kumar Saha of the BJP, from Birbhum's Dubrajpur, briefly offered grooming services. At a roadside stall, razor in hand, he shaved a voter's beard. It was not entirely clear whether the customer asked for it or whether democracy



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FOREIGN HAND!

Pakistan's motormouth defence minister **Khawaja Asif** has chugged right into Bengal's poll season, with a remark that travelled farther than perhaps

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QUESTION OF POSITION

Tamil Nadu is used to its leaders exuding a certain imperial hauteur. The late J. Jayalalithaa was the exemplar in this department—back then, India was not infrequently treated to visuals of loyalists prostrating themselves at the robed and enthroned AIADMK regina's lotus feet. In a curious throwback to those days, a kindred visual has entered—or been forcefully inserted—into the ongoing poll campaign. DMK scion **Udhayanidhi Stalin** is carting it around to rallies and showing it off to the citizenry. The giver of obeisance is the crux here, as much as its recipient. For, the picture shows the AIADMK's chief ministerial face, Edappadi K. Palaniswami

